

# Sales & Client Brief — AI Talent Lab

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Written 2026-06-13, updated same day with full market context, for the business team (non-technical). Everything you need to talk to prospects: the market we're entering, who the competitors are, what we sell, who to call, what to say, what to charge, and what *not* to promise. Source research: [05\\_market\\_validation.md](#). Questions → Srinivas.

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## 1. What we sell (in plain words)

AI Talent Lab is hiring software for companies that don't have a big recruitment team.

Today, when a company needs to hire, the HR person writes the job description by hand, posts it, digs through hundreds of resumes, chases candidates on email, coordinates interview panels on WhatsApp groups, and keeps everything in Excel. It takes the average Indian SMB **45 days to fill one position**, and recruiters spend **60–70% of their time on this repetitive work**.

Our product does that work for them:

- The HR person **describes the role in a chat** (like talking to a person) and the system writes a polished job description in minutes — checked against the market and scanned for biased language.
- Candidates **apply through a friendly chat on the company's own careers page** — no account creation, no clunky forms. Works on a phone.
- The system **reads every resume and scores it against the job** — so the recruiter reviews the best 10, not all 300.
- Interview scheduling, panel feedback, reminder emails, status updates to candidates — all handled in one place. Candidates are never ghosted; the system keeps them informed at every step.
- Every applicant goes into the company's **own private talent pool** — so the next time they hire a similar role, they already have warm, consented candidates. This pool belongs to the client, not to us and not to a job portal.

### The one-line pitch:

"Your HR person describes the role in a chat; we write the JD, collect and shortlist applicants, run the interview process, and build you a private talent bank — so you hire in weeks, not months."

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## 2. The market we're entering (the honest picture)

You've been in industry long enough to smell hype — so here's the real situation, good and bad.

What's happening out there

AI in hiring stopped being a novelty in 2025. By 2026 it's an expectation: companies now ask "how does your tool use AI?" the way they once asked "is it on the cloud?" Serious money has moved in — one AI recruiting startup (Juicebox) raised **\$36M from Sequoia** last year; another (Paradox) is the standard for conversational hiring at McDonald's-scale companies. **This is good for us**: we don't have to convince anyone that AI in hiring works. The market is educated. We have to convince them to buy it *from us*.

## Who's already in the ring, and what they actually do

| Player                                                | What they actually do                                                                                                                             | Why they don't kill us                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Paradox</b><br>(global)                            | Chat-based screening and interview scheduling for <i>huge volume</i> hiring — retail chains, BPOs, thousands of identical roles                   | Enterprise-priced, enterprise-sold. A 100-person Indian company can't buy it and Paradox won't call them. We don't compete; we avoid their segment.                                                                                         |
| <b>Juicebox, hireEZ, Pin</b><br>(global, well-funded) | AI <i>sourcing</i> — they search hundreds of millions of profiles to find candidates for US tech recruiters                                       | They fight over outbound search for the US market. Our strength is the opposite: handling <i>inbound</i> applicants brilliantly. Different game.                                                                                            |
| <b>Greenhouse, Lever, Ashby</b><br>(global)           | The "serious" ATS suites US companies use — strong on process, analytics, integrations                                                            | Dollar-priced, no India workflow (no Naukri, no WhatsApp, no DPDP, no rupee billing). Indian SMBs find them expensive and foreign.                                                                                                          |
| <b>Zoho Recruit, Keka, Freshteam</b><br>(India)       | Our <i>real</i> day-to-day competitors. Solid record-keeping: post a job, store applicants, move them through stages. ₹1,250–2,500 per user/month | They are <b>filing cabinets, not workers</b> . The HR person still writes every JD, still reads every resume, still chases everyone manually. None is chat-first; none makes candidates' experience a priority. This is the gap we live in. |
| <b>Naukri</b><br>(India)                              | The place candidates are — a resume marketplace                                                                                                   | Not a competitor, a <i>complement</i> . Clients keep Naukri; we organize what comes out of it. (And on Naukri, the candidate database belongs to Naukri — with us, it belongs to the client.)                                               |
| <b>Excel + WhatsApp + memory</b>                      | How most of our actual prospects hire today                                                                                                       | This is who we really replace. Our biggest competitor is "the way we've always done it."                                                                                                                                                    |

**Where the gap is:** global AI tools are built for enterprises and priced in dollars; Indian tools are affordable but passive. **Nobody serves the Indian SMB that wants the work *done*, at a price that makes sense.** That's our lane.

## How we survive (and what would kill us)

A fair question from any prospect — or any of you: "*Zoho is huge; what happens when they add AI?*"

Our survival plan, in order:

1. **Stay in our lane.** We don't fight Paradox for enterprises or Juicebox for US sourcing. We win the India SMB inbound-hiring niche that's too small for giants to prioritize and too workflow-specific for them to serve well.
2. **The talent pool makes clients sticky.** Every month a client uses us, their private candidate database grows. After 6 months, leaving us means abandoning an asset. A competitor can copy our features; they can't copy our client's accumulated data.

- 3. **Candidate experience is our reputation engine.** Candidates who apply through us have a pleasant experience and are never ghosted. They talk. Their next employer hears about it. The big suites have ignored candidates for a decade — it's culturally hard for them to change.
- 4. **India-specific depth incumbents won't rush:** WhatsApp outreach, DPDP consent handling, rupee pricing, Naukri-aware workflow. Zoho *will* add generic AI eventually; matching our workflow depth for this niche is a different bet for them.
- 5. **Speed and founder attention.** Ten pilot clients get the founder's personal onboarding and their feedback shipped in weeks. No incumbent offers that.

What would actually kill us: **not the competition — slow client acquisition.** The product is ahead of where the company is. Which is exactly why your role is the critical one right now.

What success looks like (so we all aim at the same target)

| Horizon          | The bar                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 90 days          | 25 discovery calls in the first month → <b>3–5 paying pilot clients</b> → at least <b>1 real hire</b> made through the platform. This proves the business.                                                          |
| 12 months        | 15–25 paying clients, 2–3 written case studies with numbers ("time-to-fill cut from 45 to 20 days"), WhatsApp + job-portal posting shipped — making us clearly the India-SMB choice.                                |
| If 90 days fails | Fewer than 3 pilots from 25+ real conversations = the segment or pitch is wrong. We regroup and adjust target market — <i>that's a finding, not a failure</i> . Honest call notes matter more than optimistic ones. |

3. Who to sell to (ideal client profile)

|                         | Target                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Company size            | <b>50–500 employees, India</b>                                                                                                                              |
| Hiring volume           | 5–30 hires a year (enough pain, no dedicated recruitment ops)                                                                                               |
| Who signs               | Founder, HR Head, or the one overworked HR generalist                                                                                                       |
| Best-fit signs          | Growing tech/tech-adjacent company; hiring via Naukri + Excel + WhatsApp today; complains about time-to-hire or candidate quality; no ATS, or an unused one |
| Poor fit (skip for now) | Mass/blue-collar volume hiring (thousands of applicants — that's Paradox territory); enterprises wanting SSO and procurement cycles; staffing agencies      |

**Trigger moments to listen for:** just raised funding · opening a new office/team · HR person quit · founder still interviewing everyone personally · "we lost a great candidate because we replied late."

4. Why we win (say it in their language)

1. **It does the work, not just stores the data.** Zoho Recruit and Keka are filing cabinets — you still write the JD, still screen resumes. We actually do those steps.
2. **Candidates love it, so clients get more applicants.** Applying takes minutes in a chat on the phone — no logins, no forms. And nobody gets ghosted; the system keeps every candidate informed. Companies' employer brand improves; better candidates say yes.
3. **The client builds an asset.** Every application enriches their own private talent pool. After 6 months they fill some roles without posting at all. Nobody else offers them this — on Naukri, the database belongs to Naukri.
4. **A human makes every decision.** The AI drafts, scores, and suggests — it never auto-rejects anyone. Important for fairness, and an easy answer when prospects worry about "AI hiring."
5. **Built for India.** Rupee pricing, DPDP-compliant data handling and consent, WhatsApp outreach on the roadmap, and the global tools (Greenhouse, Lever, Ashby) are dollar-priced for Silicon Valley.

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## 5. Competition cheat sheet (quick answers on a call)

| If they say...                        | You say...                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "We use <b>Naukri</b> "               | "Keep it — we organize what comes from it. Naukri gives you a pile of resumes; we shortlist, schedule, and track them. And your applicants build <i>your</i> database, not Naukri's."                                           |
| "We use <b>Zoho Recruit / Keka</b> "  | "Those track candidates; they don't do the work. Ask your HR how long the last JD took, and how many resumes they read manually. We chat-generate the JD and auto-shortlist. Also: how do candidates feel applying through it?" |
| "We use <b>Excel + WhatsApp</b> "     | Best prospect. "You're spending senior people's time on copy-paste. One missed follow-up = one lost candidate. We replace exactly that — for less than a junior recruiter's day of salary per month."                           |
| "What about <b>global AI tools?</b> " | "Dollar-priced, built for US enterprises, no India workflow (Naukri, WhatsApp, DPDP). We're built here, priced here."                                                                                                           |
| " <b>ChatGPT</b> writes our JDs"      | "Great — that's 1 of the 15 steps. ChatGPT doesn't collect applications, score resumes, schedule interviews, or remember candidates for your next role."                                                                        |
| "What if <b>Zoho adds AI?</b> "       | "They'll add a generic AI button eventually. We're built AI-first for exactly your size of company, your data stays your asset with us, and you get the founder on the phone — not a ticket queue."                             |

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## 6. Pricing (you may quote this)

**Founder pilot pricing — first 10 clients only:**

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|             |                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Price       | ₹2,999–4,999 / month depending on company size and roles (use your judgment within the band)                                                                              |
| Includes    | Full product, personal onboarding by the founder, direct support line, input into the roadmap                                                                             |
| Billing     | Manual invoice for now (monthly or quarterly); annual prepay → 2 months free                                                                                              |
| Frame it as | "Founder pricing — you get the product early at a fraction of the eventual list price (₹15k+/mo tier planned), in exchange for feedback and a reference if you're happy." |

No free tier promises, no custom-feature commitments without checking first.

## 7. What NOT to promise (read carefully)

These are coming but **not live today**. Overselling here burns the client and the pilot.

| Don't promise                                     | Reality today                                                                                | Safe phrasing                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| WhatsApp messages to candidates                   | Email only today; WhatsApp is on the roadmap                                                 | "Email today, WhatsApp is on the near-term roadmap"         |
| Auto-posting jobs to Naukri/LinkedIn              | Not yet — client's careers page + shareable links                                            | "You get a branded careers page; portal posting is planned" |
| Candidates self-booking interview slots           | Recruiter schedules in-app; calendar sync in progress                                        | "Scheduling is in the product; self-booking is coming"      |
| "It finds candidates from LinkedIn automatically" | Outbound sourcing is limited; our strength is handling <b>inbound</b> applicants brilliantly | Lead with the inbound story, always                         |
| Mobile app                                        | Mobile-friendly web (works well on phones), no app store app                                 | "Works fully on the phone browser"                          |
| Integrations with HRMS/payroll                    | Not yet                                                                                      | "On the roadmap, driven by client demand"                   |

**Security questions:** safe to say — "Each company's data is fully isolated, sensitive data like salary expectations is encrypted, candidates give explicit consent (DPDP), and any candidate can request deletion of their data. Detailed security note available on request" (founder provides).

## 8. Objection handling

- **"AI will reject good people."** It never rejects anyone — it ranks and explains. Every decision is made by your team. The AI just saves them the reading time.
- **"Our data / candidate salaries are sensitive."** Isolated per company, salary data encrypted, consent-based, deletable on request. Frankly stronger hygiene than emailing resumes around.
- **"Too expensive."** One bad hire or one month of delay costs more than a year of this. ₹3–5k/month is less than one Naukri add-on, and a fraction of an agency's 8.33% fee.

- **"We're too small / hire rarely."** Fair — park them, take their number for the talent-pool story later. Don't force poor fits into pilots.
- **"Is your company too new / will you be around?"** Honest answer: early-stage, founder-built, which is why they get founder pricing, direct access, and influence on the roadmap. Their data is exportable — they're never locked in.

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## 9. The motion (what a "win" looks like)

1. **Discovery call (20 min):** their hiring volume, current process, time-to-fill, biggest pain. Qualify against §3. *Goal: book a demo.*
2. **Demo (30 min, founder joins initially):** the story is one role going through — chat → JD → careers page → candidate applies on a phone → shortlist appears → interview booked.
3. **Paid pilot:** founder pricing, 1–3 live positions, founder onboards them personally.
4. **After 60 days:** review results together (time-to-fill, applicants handled, hires made) → reference + case study.

Targets are in §2 ("What success looks like"): 25 calls in 30 days → 3–5 paid pilots by day 90.

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## 10. Jargon translator (terms you'll hear)

| Term                | Means                                                                                       |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ATS                 | Applicant Tracking System — software that manages job applicants                            |
| JD                  | Job Description                                                                             |
| Pipeline            | The list of candidates for a role and what stage each is at                                 |
| Sourcing            | Finding candidates (vs. them applying to you)                                               |
| Screening           | First-pass filtering of applicants                                                          |
| Magic link          | A login-free link we email — candidate/panelist clicks and they're in, no password          |
| Talent pool         | The client's private, reusable database of past applicants                                  |
| Time-to-fill        | Days from "we need to hire" to offer accepted (India SMB average: ~45)                      |
| DPDP                | India's data-protection law (like Europe's GDPR) — we're built for it                       |
| Inbound vs outbound | Inbound = candidates apply to you; outbound = you go hunting for them. We're inbound-first. |